

HARBOURLIGHT ROWING CLUB

Annual Report 2024

Our 87th season on the river at Port Allery



Presented to members at the Annual General Meeting on 15 February 2025.

Harbourlight Rowing Club

The Boathouse, Quay Road
Port Allery PA3 7RW

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SECTION 1

Chair's foreword

2024 was a year of steady water and full boats. We began the season with a waiting list for the learn-to-row course and ended it with more active members than at any time since the boathouse was rebuilt in 2009. None of that happens by accident: it is the work of coaches, captains, boat repairers, bar volunteers and the many members who simply turn up, carry a boat and get on with it.

The highlight of the summer was the Port Allery Regatta, which we hosted for the first time in eleven years. Over two days, 412 crews raced on a course that the harbour authority had widened for us. The rain held off until the very last race. I would like to thank the regatta committee, who planned the event for almost a year and ran it without a single protest.

Not everything went to plan. A spring flood closed the river for nineteen days in March, and the boathouse doors needed an urgent repair that used most of the contingency budget. The committee has since agreed a maintenance plan, so that repairs of this kind are funded in advance rather than found at short notice.

This report sets out what we did, what it cost and what we intend to do next. The accounts summarised in section 6 were approved by the committee on 9 January 2025 and will be presented at the Annual General Meeting, where every member can ask questions about them.

Thank you all for a remarkable season. I look forward to seeing you on the water in the spring.

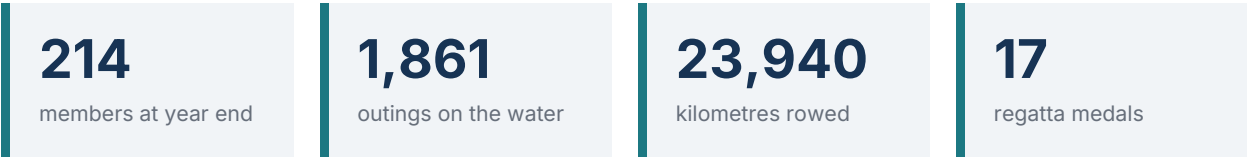
Margaret Okafor

Chair, Harbourlight Rowing Club

SECTION 2

The year in numbers

The figures below come from the club’s booking system, which records every outing, and from the membership register at the end of each month. An outing is one crew taking one boat on the water, whatever the size of the boat.



Outings per month, 2024

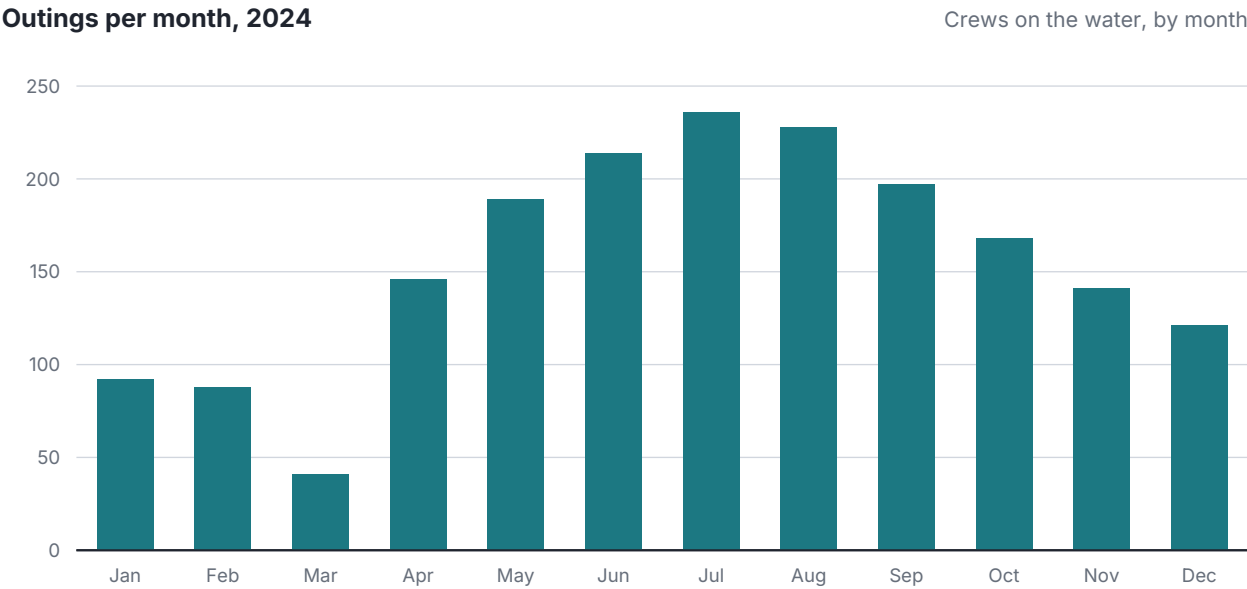


Figure 1. Outings per month, 2024. The river was closed from 4 to 22 March after the spring flood.

Summer remains our busiest time, but the winter months are catching up: November and December outings rose by a quarter compared with 2023, helped by the new lights on the landing stage and a winter training plan for the recreational squad.

SECTION 3

Membership

Membership grew from 188 to 214 over the year. Most of the growth came from adults who completed the learn-to-row course and stayed on: 31 of the 36 course graduates joined as full members.

Members at month end

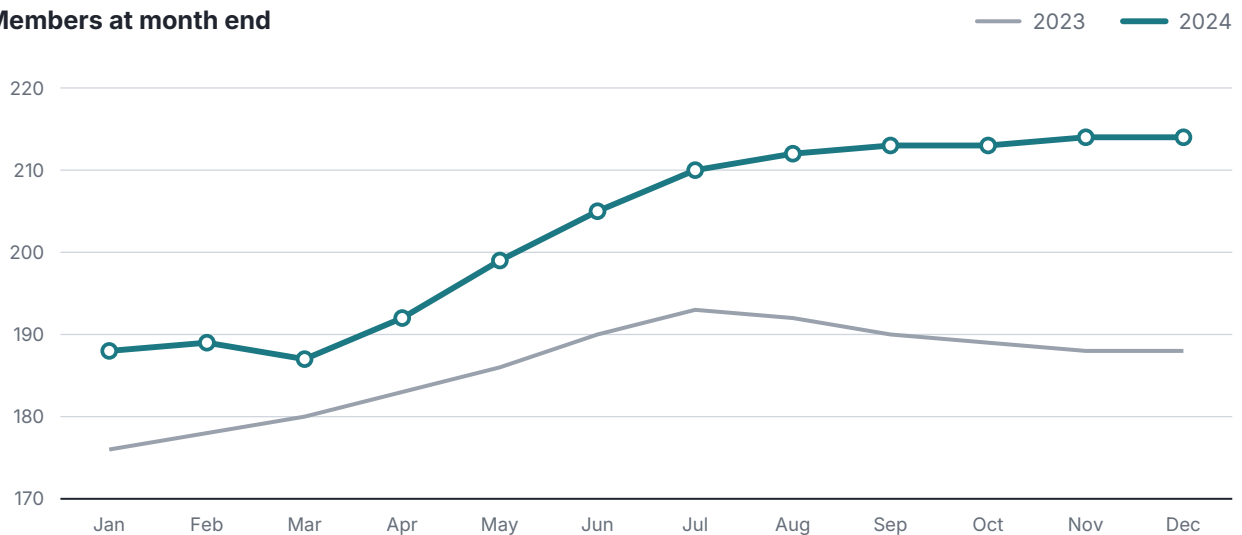


Figure 2. Members at month end, 2023 and 2024. Each point is the register count on the last day of the month.

Who our members are

Juniors aged 12 to 18 make up a fifth of the club. Our oldest active member turned 84 in June and still sculls twice a week. Just under half of the membership now rows recreationally, without racing, and this is the fastest-growing group.

Fees

Fees for 2024 were unchanged. The committee proposes a rise of 4 percent from April 2025, the first since 2021, to cover higher insurance premiums and the fuel for the coaching launch.

SECTION 4

Racing and regattas

Our crews raced at fourteen events, from small local heads to the national masters championships. They brought home 17 medals: six gold, five silver and six bronze, the best haul since 2016.

Port Allery Regatta

After eleven years away, the regatta returned to our stretch of the river in July. Crews came from 38 clubs, and the course ran from the old swing bridge to the boathouse, finishing in front of a crowded bank. The event made a surplus of £17,900, which goes into the boat replacement fund.

Running a regatta takes more than a hundred volunteers. Umpires, marshals, timekeepers and the catering team worked long days, and many of them were parents of juniors who had never been to a regatta before.

Highlights

- Women's masters coxed four: gold at the Northern Masters, winning by two lengths.
- Junior double sculls: silver at the regional championships in their first season together.
- Men's eight: fastest club crew at the Autumn Head on 12 October.
- Adaptive single sculls: two wins at the inclusive regatta in Westerby.

Racing costs are met by the racing squad itself through crew fees and sponsorship, so racing is not subsidised by the wider membership.

SECTION 5

Fleet and boathouse

The club owns 22 boats. Eight of them do most of the work, and the table shows how often each was taken out. Outings are counted from the booking system; a boat used for a coaching session counts once per session.

Table 1. Fleet register: the eight most used boats, 2024

Boat	Type	Built	Outings	Condition
Kittiwake	Coxed four	2012	214	Good
Grey Heron	Eight	2016	187	Good
Tern	Double scull	2019	243	Very good
Cormorant	Coxed four	2008	165	Fair
Dunlin	Single scull	2021	198	Very good
Curlew	Single scull	2014	172	Good
Shearwater	Quad scull	2018	205	Good
Puffin	Coastal four	2022	131	Very good

Boathouse

The spring flood left 30 centimetres of water in the lower bay. The boats had been lifted in time, but the doors and the electrics needed repair. The work was finished in May at a cost of £7,860, of which insurance covered £5,200.

In the autumn, volunteers fitted new racks for the single sculls and repainted the landing stage. A grant from the Port Allery Community Fund paid for the new lights.

SECTION 6

Finances

The club ended the year with a small surplus of £2,140, against a budgeted surplus of £4,500. Income rose to £96,300, mainly from membership fees and the regatta; spending rose to £94,160, mainly because of the flood repairs.

Income

Membership fees brought in £58,400 and the regatta £17,900 after costs. Room hire, now offered on Friday and Saturday evenings, added £8,700. The remaining £11,300 came from grants, donations and the bar.

Spending

The largest costs were coaching (£21,900), the boathouse (£27,460 including repairs), insurance (£14,800) and boat maintenance (£12,600). Utilities, the coaching launch and administration made up the remaining £17,400.

Reserves

Reserves stand at £41,800, which covers about five months of running costs. The committee aims to keep at least four months in reserve and to set aside £6,000 a year for boat replacement, starting in 2025.

The full accounts, with the independent examiner's report, are available from the Treasurer and will be on display at the boathouse in the two weeks before the meeting.

SECTION 7

Community and juniors

The junior squad trained three times a week with 42 regular rowers. Two juniors were selected for the regional development squad, and four took their first coaching qualification.

Schools and open days

We ran rowing taster sessions for three local schools and held two open days, in May and September, which together brought 260 visitors to the boathouse. The adaptive rowing group, launched in 2023, now meets every Saturday morning with its own specially fitted boat.

Volunteers

Volunteers gave an estimated 6,400 hours to the club this year. Without them there would be no coaching, no regatta and no tea after Sunday outings. Our thanks go to every one of them.

SECTION 8

The year ahead

The committee's priorities for 2025 are a replacement for Cormorant, the oldest four in the fleet, better changing rooms, and a second learn-to-row course in the autumn.

Plans

- Order a new coxed four by June, funded from the boat reserve and a members' appeal.
- Refurbish the changing rooms over the winter, subject to a grant decision in March.
- Run two learn-to-row courses, in April and September.

Officers for 2025

Chair	Margaret Okafor
Secretary	Tom Ashdown
Treasurer	Priya Raman
Captain	Daniel Whitlock
Junior coordinator	Aylin Demir

The Annual General Meeting will be held at the boathouse on 15 February 2025 at 7 pm. All members are welcome, and nominations for the committee close a week before.